

Organizational justice research: A review, synthesis, and research agenda

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Abstract

We conducted a general, semi-systematic literature review on organizational justice. Based on this review, we first explored the various ways in which organizational justice was conceptualized. Second, we explained the importance of organizational justice by reviewing and synthesizing theoretical frameworks in organizational justice research and studies that analyzed the effects of justice on employee outcomes. Subsequently, we shifted the focus from the individual to the team level by reviewing and synthesizing justice climate and peer justice research. To expand prior research and stimulate future research, we presented several avenues for future research, such as the cultural sensitivity of justice, justice in diverse work environments, justice and conflict, and the changing nature of work and justice. We also created a theoretical foundation for the integration of organizational justice with research on workplace conflict, diversity and dissimilarity, cultural values, relationships with coworkers, and the changing nature of work.

KEYWORDS

conflict, cross-cultural research, diversity, fairness, groups/teams, justice perceptions, organizational justice, social justice

INTRODUCTION

Justice in business and work is important for moral and ethical reasons. This is illustrated by financial and business scandals, including the exploitation of third-world populations by multinational textile companies (Global Slavery Index, 2018), multi-million-dollar compensation for CEOs of loss-making companies (The New York Times, 2020), the high number of tax havens (Transparency International, 2019), bribery and corruption in many countries (Ramamoorthy, Kulkarni, & Gupta, 2015), and recent cryptocurrency scams (Financial Times, 2022). Acting in a just way is not only the right thing to do but to do so is also an attractive business opportunity (Brockner, 2010; Lind et al., 2000). Managers can use justice as an effective tool to increase employees' job satisfaction, organizational identification, and job performance (Colquitt et al., 2013). It also decreases employees' turnover intentions, the need for retaliation, and engagement in counterproductive work behaviors, such as conflict or theft (Rupp et al., 2014).

Furthermore, treating employees with justice is a precondition for establishing effective relationships with employees (Cropanzano & Rupp, 2008). Treating employees with justice will make managers appear to be better people and leaders (Byrne et al., 2012).

Organizational justice is the study of employees' perceptions of justice in the workplace (Colquitt, 2001). Prior research shows that employees evaluate a workplace based on four dimensions: (1) just pay and outcomes, (2) just decision-making procedures, (3) respectful and dignified treatment, and (4) accurate and honest communication (Colquitt, 2001). Organizational justice research has further demonstrated the importance of justice for employees in a variety of organizational settings, such as pay systems, selection, layoffs, performance evaluations, corporate ethics programs, and social enterprises (Cropanzano & Ambrose, 2015; Cropanzano et al., 2007; Moliner, Cropanzano, & Martínez-Tur, 2017). By acting in a just way, managers can improve their workplace culture, reputation, and performance (Colquitt et al., 2013; Rupp et al., 2014).

To expand previous organizational justice reviews (e.g., Colquitt, 2012; Colquitt & Rodell, 2015; Cropanzano & Ambrose, 2015; Moliner, Martínez-Tur, & Cropanzano, 2017; Rupp et al., 2017) and to motivate managers to create workplaces, we present a review, synthesis, and future topics of organizational justice research (Table 1). First, our semi-systematic review (see Grant & Booth, 2009; Snyder, 2019) clarified the conceptualization of organizational justice by explaining its definitions and dimensions, as well as the distinction between justice and injustice. Has organizational justice research developed meaningful concepts and established construct validity? Second, our semi-systematic review provided information about the utility and importance of organizational justice research by reviewing and synthesizing research on theoretical approaches to explain why employees cared about justice and the effects of the work environment on employee outcomes. Third, we shifted

the focus of organizational justice research from the individual level to the team level by reviewing and synthesizing research on justice climates and peer justice. Finally, we identified several research gaps and presented topics that require future research, such as the cultural sensitivity of justice, justice in a diverse work environment, justice and conflict, and the changing nature of work and justice. These are key themes and lines of inquiry that need to be deepened in the future. We expand on previous reviews by creating a theoretical foundation for the integration of organizational justice with research on workplace conflict, diversity and dissimilarity, cultural values, and the changing nature of work. These topics have often been neglected in previous literature reviews and in organizational justice research.

PROCEDURES FOR LITERATURE REVIEW

Semi-systematic literature review

To conduct our semi-systematic literature review, we followed the best practices and guidelines of previous research (Chamakiotis, Panteli, & Davison, 2021; Grant & Booth, 2009; Snyder, 2019). The main difference between a general semi-systematic literature review (also known as a state-of-the-art literature review) and a systematic literature review is the degree of structure used in the review process. A systematic literature review is a formal and structured approach that uses a predefined set of criteria to identify and evaluate relevant research studies. This approach was designed to provide a highly structured and exhaustive overview of the available literature on a given topic. Presenting a number of manuscripts and clear decision criteria are important for a systematic literature review.

In contrast, a general semi-systematic literature review is less formal and structured and may not use a strict set of criteria to identify and evaluate research studies (e.g., Chamakiotis, Panteli, & Davison, 2021; Dabić et al., 2022; Dagnino, Picone, & Ferrigno, 2021; Fuduric et al., 2022; Grant & Booth, 2009; Henry & Lewis, 2023; Snyder, 2019; Verschuere, Brandsen, & Pestoff, 2012). This approach is more flexible and allows for more creativity and a broader overview of the available literature but may not be as structured, exhaustive, or quantitative as a systematic literature review. Overall, the main difference between these two types of literature reviews is the level of structure used in the review process.

A general semi-systematic review was conducted because of its better “ability to map a field of research, synthesise the state of knowledge, and create an agenda for further research” (Snyder, 2019: 335) and its facilitation of the development of “new perspectives on an issue or highlights areas in need of further research” (Grant & Booth, 2009: 105). These two strengths of a semi-

TABLE 1 Classification of prior organizational justice research.

Conceptualization of organizational justice	Description
Definition of organizational justice	Subjective versus objective justice
Dimensions of organizational justice	What are the different dimensions of justice?
Overall justice	Justice dimensions versus overall justice
Justice versus injustice	Is bad stronger than good?
Importance of organizational justice	Description
Theoretical justice perspectives	Why do employees care about justice?
Justice effects on employee outcomes	What are the effects of employees' justice perceptions on employee outcomes in different organizational settings?
Organizational justice in the context of teams	Description
Justice climate	Analyzing employees' justice perceptions at the team level of analysis
Peer justice	Analyzing coworker justice
Research agenda for organizational justice	Description
Cultural sensitivity of justice perceptions	Do justice norms differ across countries?
Justice and diversity	Creating a just environment for minority workers
Justice–conflict relationship	Why, how, and when are organizational justice and workplace conflict related to each other?
Changing nature of work and organizational justice	Adopting a justice lens to analyze current topics such as telework, gig workers, and integration of refugees

systematic review fit well with the manuscript's two main goals: (1) mapping and synthesizing previous organizational justice research and (2) developing an agenda for future organizational justice research. A semi-systematic review is also helpful for developing new themes and theoretical perspectives or identifying common problems within a research stream (Snyder, 2019; Ward, House, & Hamer, 2009).

Furthermore, a general semi-systematic review requires stricter rules and exclusion/inclusion criteria. Instead, it is driven by the researcher's understanding and expertise in the research area, following an interpretive understanding of the field and thematic analysis of the reviewed manuscripts (Braun & Clarke, 2006). The following four phases were followed for the semi-systematic review: design (i.e., developing rationale and study goals), conducting the literature research (i.e., literature search, selecting manuscripts, storing manuscripts, and presenting an overview), analysis of the manuscripts (i.e., thematic analysis that led to several themes), and structuring and writing the review (i.e., developing and explaining overall and sub-themes) (Snyder, 2019: 336). A weakness of a semi-systematic review is that it is less objective than a systematic review. A semi-systematic review can also be influenced by the personal perspectives of the author and subject expert.

Search procedures and selection of articles

The lead author's 5-year-old bibliographic library on organizational justice research was used as a starting point for the literature review. This bibliography is the result of the author's PhD thesis on organizational justice. As organizational justice is an interdisciplinary research stream, the bibliography is based on a broad literature search using the following search engines: Google Scholar, Web of Science, Business Source Complete, Scopus, and ProQuest. Empirical studies, meta-analyses, theoretical articles, literature reviews, book chapters, and dissertations were also included. The following search terms were used: organizational justice, justice and the workplace, justice and management, justice and business, and justice and leadership. At the start of creating the bibliographic library of organizational justice research in 2015, nearly 2500 manuscripts were reported through a Google Scholar search using the terms organizational justice, justice and workplace, justice and management, justice and business, and justice and leadership. This high number of manuscripts suggests that reviewing every single manuscript as part of a systematic review is not possible, requiring a different approach in terms of a semi-systematic review, as described in the previous section. A semi-systematic review is used for research streams such as organizational justice, which has been studied in different disciplines, thereby making a full systematic review process very difficult (Snyder, 2019; Wong et al., 2013).

After 2016, the bibliography was continuously updated until 2021, with more recent publications in top journals (particularly A and A* journals of the ABDC list) and handbooks about organizational justice. All articles were read several times by the lead author.

We focused on methodologically rigorous studies published in peer-reviewed journals. To evaluate whether a study was methodologically rigorous, the following key characteristics were used: (a) clear hypotheses, (b) valid and reliable measures (Cronbach's alpha and confirmatory factor analyses or exploratory factor analyses), (c) appropriate analysis (transparent analysis, correlation table, linear regression, or structural equation modeling), (d) a large sample to test the hypotheses, and (e) clear reporting of results. Overall, methodologically rigorous studies should be carefully designed and conducted to ensure that the results of the studies are valid and reliable. We also included book chapters (mostly published in handbooks on organizational justice) to complement the discussion. We further focused on articles that introduced a new topic in organizational justice research (e.g., overall justice, justice climate, and new theoretical explanations to explain justice effects) or that advanced a topic by taking a new methodological approach compared to prior research (e.g., team-level measure of justice, second-order justice research, and measurement of injustice instead of justice).

Through this process, the initial bibliography was reduced to articles listed in the reference list of this manuscript. While the resulting bibliography is smaller than that for a systematic review, the bibliography of a semi-systematic review tends to comprise more relevant and important papers, which is in line with the manuscript's goals of synthesizing previous organizational justice research and developing an agenda for future research (Henry & Lewis, 2023). However, we acknowledge that a semi-systematic review approach may have led to omitted studies.

Thematic analysis

After the literature search, the articles were analyzed several times to develop appropriate classifications of prior organizational justice research, enabling us to provide a review, synthesis, and research agenda. The thematic analysis in this manuscript was based on Braun and Clarke's (2006) phases of theme search, theme review, and theme definition/naming. Given that the lead author was already aware of this literature, the focus was on methodologically rigorous studies that introduced a new concept in organizational justice research. This literature presented the foundation of the manuscript's work and helped identify research gaps to create recommendations for future research.

The following classification was developed: (1) organizational justice at the individual level, (2) organizational

justice at the team level, and (3) integrating the organizational context into organizational justice research. After receiving feedback and to better identify research gaps and provide a future research agenda, the classification was changed to (1) past debates in organizational justice research, (2) current debates in organizational justice research, and (3) future debates in organizational justice research. However, a problem with this classification was that several research topics overlap with several sub-dimensions. For example, “justice effects on employee outcomes” is a sub-dimension that could have been classified under past or current debates, whereas “peer justice” could have been classified under current or future debates. To solve these classification issues, another classification was developed: (1) the conceptualization of organizational justice, (2) the importance of organizational justice, (3) organizational justice in the context of teams, and (4) a research agenda for organizational justice research. Based on this classification, several sub-dimensions were developed for these four dimensions.

1. The dimension “conceptualization of organizational justice” has four sub-dimensions:
 - a. Definition of organizational justice
 - b. Dimensions of organizational justice
 - c. Overall justice
 - d. Justice versus injustice
2. The dimension “importance of organizational justice” has two sub-dimensions:
 - a. Theoretical justice perspectives
 - b. Justice effects on employee outcomes
3. The dimension “organizational justice in the context of teams” has two sub-dimensions:
 - a. Justice climate
 - b. Peer justice
4. The dimension “research agenda for organizational justice research” has four sub-dimensions:
 - a. The cultural sensitivity of justice perceptions
 - b. Justice in a diverse work environment
 - c. Integrating organizational justice and conflict research in the workplace
 - d. The changing nature of work and justice

Finally, as recommended by prior research (Chamakiotis, Panteli, & Davison, 2021; Grant & Booth, 2009; Snyder, 2019), the structure of the article reflects this classification of dimensions and subdimensions.

CONCEPTUALIZATION OF ORGANIZATIONAL JUSTICE

Definition of organizational justice

Writers and philosophers in different parts of the world (Sen, 2009) have discussed the definition of justice over hundreds of years. Discussions on the definition, establishment, and effects of justice can be traced back to ancient Greece, when Plato, Socrates, and Aristotle dealt with justice. For instance, Aristotle described and theorized in his *Nicomachean Ethics* different justice interpretations that can be classified into distributive justice, equality, corrective justice, and reciprocity (Burger, 2009). Although some traditional definitions of this philosophical justice perspective can be found in organizational justice, clear differences exist between the traditional philosophical justice perspective and the field of organizational justice (Cropanzano & Stein, 2009; Greenberg & Bies, 1992; Table 1).

Philosophical justice uses a prescriptive approach toward justice, whereas organizational justice uses a descriptive approach (Crawshaw et al., 2013). This means that philosophers and ethics scholars are interested in defining objective justice principles that should function as guides for our feelings, thoughts, and actions. Their goals are the creation and implementation of normative and objective justice norms and standards, which are universally applied in every society and organization. In other words, philosophical justice attempts to define what is right and wrong.

By contrast, organizational justice scholars try to understand how justice is perceived by people and what people evaluate as just. Therefore, the focus of organizational justice is on subjective justice, not objective justice. According to the organizational justice framework, justice is socially constructed and lies in the eyes of the beholder. A normative perspective of justice is usually not included in organizational justice research, and creating universal justice standards is not considered the main goal of this field of research. The main objectives of organizational justice are to measure, analyze, and evaluate the effects of subjective justice perceptions in the workplace (Greenberg & Colquitt, 2005).

Dimensions of organizational justice

Next, we defined the four justice dimensions that are the central elements of organizational justice: distributive,

procedural, interpersonal, and informational justice (Colquitt, 2001). However, it is also important to mention that some studies use a three-factor model that combines interpersonal and informational justice with interactional justice (e.g., Blader & Tyler, 2009).

Distributive justice

One central element of employees' work experience is the evaluation of the justice of decision outcomes (e.g., salary, promotion, and performance evaluation), which is referred to as distributive justice (Adams, 1965; Deutsch, 1975). One main basis of distributive justice is equity theory (Adams, 1965), the starting point of which is an exchange relationship between at least two actors. The inputs and outputs are then exchanged. Examples of inputs include quality of work, quantity of work, effort, expertise, skills, and loyalty (Adams, 1965; Ambrose & Arnaud, 2005; Leung, 2005; Törnblom & Kazemi, 2011). Examples of outputs include salary, bonuses, promotions, performance appraisals, and status symbols (Adams, 1965; Ambrose & Arnaud, 2005; Colquitt et al., 2001; Colquitt, Greenberg, & Zapata-Phelan, 2005). The ratio of outputs to inputs determines the perceived justice of allocation. Employees form an outcome/input ratio (O_1/I_1) and compare their ratio to the ratio of similar others, such as coworkers (O_2/I_2) (Cropanzano et al., 2007). Although equity is considered the central allocation norm of distributive justice, the application of other allocation norms is also possible (Deutsch, 1975, 1985; Leventhal 1976; Leventhal et al., 1980; Romaine & Schmidt, 2008). These allocation norms are referred to as equality and need. Applying equality as an allocation norm, the allocator distributes outcomes equally among people independent of their inputs (Deutsch, 1985). If need is used as the allocation norm, the allocator distributes outcomes to those who have the greatest need (e.g., financial needs) for receiving the outcomes (Deutsch, 1985).

Procedural justice

The consideration of both decision outcomes and formal decision-making procedures that are utilized to determine the outcomes are important. Employees often ask themselves, particularly in the case of negative outcomes (Brockner, 2010), how their managers or organizations have made their decisions. They are concerned with the justice of decision-making procedures, called procedural justice (Leventhal, 1980; Thibaut & Walker, 1975). The introduction of procedural justice can be credited to Thibaut and Walker (1975). In a legal dispute setting, Thibaut and Walker found that process control contributes, independent of decision control, to perceptions of justice. Leventhal (1980) further expanded the concept of

procedural justice by transforming the results of Thibaut and Walkers into a resource allocation context. He defined procedural justice as the perceived justice of procedures that structure outcome allocation. This has become a common definition of procedural justice. Leventhal proposed six norms as antecedents for establishing just procedures: consistency, bias suppression, accuracy, correctability, representativeness, and ethicality.

Interactional justice: Interpersonal and informational justice

In addition to formal procedures, employees value the interpersonal treatment they receive from authorities. The justice of interpersonal treatment, introduced by Bies and Moag in 1986, is called interactional justice. They defined interactional justice as the quality of interpersonal treatment people receive during the enactment of formal decision-making procedures. Bies and Moag (1986) introduced four interactional justice norms: respect, propriety, truthfulness, and justification. Greenberg (1993) further classified interactional justice in two dimensions, which can be named interpersonal and informational justice (Colquitt, 2001). Greenberg (1993) defined interpersonal justice as the social side of distributive justice and informational justice as the social side of procedural justice. The rules identified by Bies and Moag (1986) remained the same. Interpersonal justice is based on the rules of respect and propriety, whereas informational justice is based on the rules of truthfulness and justification.

In summary, the study of justice perceptions in the workplace has experienced unprecedented development, from equity theory in 1965 to a multidimensional construct. Equity theory, procedural justice rules, and the perceived justice of interpersonal treatment emerged during this period. The issue of construct validity, which has plagued the advancement of organizational justice research over several years, has become less important because numerous empirical studies have provided support for the four-factor taxonomy of organizational justice (Colquitt, 2012; Colquitt et al., 2013).

Overall justice

A combination of justice dimensions with one global justice construct has been discussed and investigated in-depth in organizational justice literature (Ambrose & Schminke, 2009; Colquitt, 2012; Holtz & Harold, 2009; Nauman, Zheng, & Naseer, 2020). Although the classification of organizational justice into four dimensions is accepted by many justice scholars (Colquitt, 2012; Colquitt et al., 2013), other conceptualizations of organizational justice have also been discussed (Rupp

et al., 2017), resulting from the high multicollinearity among the justice dimensions. The justice dimensions often have high correlations that range between 0.37 and 0.74 in meta-analyses (Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001; Colquitt et al., 2001, 2013; Fassina, Jones, & Uggerslev, 2008).

Based on the high correlations between justice dimensions, the possibility of combining single justice dimensions with an overall justice construct arises automatically (Ambrose & Arnaud, 2005; Colquitt & Shaw, 2005). This question has been neglected for a long time (Ambrose & Arnaud, 2005), although Lind and Tyler discussed the implications of distributive and procedural justice for the formation of overall justice perceptions in 1988 (see also Lind, 2001). The reason for low interest in overall justice is related to the common research approach in organizational justice. Justice researchers have focused on the unique variance explained by justice dimensions to distinguish them from each other and to compare their relative importance in explaining specific outcomes (Ambrose & Arnaud, 2005).

The renewed interest in overall justice began with Lind's (2001) work. He highlighted the role of justice dimensions in forming overall justice perceptions, which function as guides for employees' attitudes and behavior. General impressions of justice should have a stronger impact on employees' outcomes than individual justice dimensions. Ambrose and Schminke (2009) further argued that most of the hypotheses in empirical studies were not based on justice dimensions, but rather on overall justice perceptions. They also reported that the effects of justice dimensions (i.e., distributive, procedural, and interaction) on job satisfaction, commitment, and turnover intentions are transmitted through overall justice. Therefore, it seems important to measure overall justice in addition to justice dimensions because overall justice might be a more proximal predictor of employee outcomes.

Advantages exist for the use of single justice dimensions, as well as for the use of an overall justice construct (Colquitt, 2012; Colquitt & Shaw, 2005). In addition to the multicollinearity issue, the effect sizes of justice would be more stable if an overall justice measure were used, leading to a faster accumulation of results in organizational justice research (Colquitt & Shaw, 2005). The application of an overall justice measure could also facilitate the inclusion of organizational justice in other research areas. A short 3- or 6-item scale to measure overall justice is easier to include in a survey than 20 items for justice dimensions (Colquitt & Shaw, 2005).

Two possibilities exist to measure overall justice perceptions: (a) overall justice can be measured directly through items like "just" (Ambrose & Schminke, 2009; Colquitt & Rodell, 2015; Colquitt & Shaw, 2005), or (b) overall justice can be modeled as a higher-order latent variable based on the justice dimensions, meaning that organizational justice would be a real construct and not a

literature label (Colquitt, 2012; Colquitt & Shaw, 2005; Fassina, Jones, & Uggerslev, 2008; Liao, 2007). Existing research indicates strong effects of overall justice on workplace outcomes (e.g., Priesemuth et al., 2013).

The measurement of the four dimensions of individual justice also has merits. Measuring different justice norms helps justice researchers provide more specific recommendations for managers and organizations (Colquitt & Shaw, 2005). A training intervention focusing on organizational justice might also be easier to conduct if all justice dimensions and norms are measured (Greenberg, 2009; Skarlicki & Latham, 2005).

Justice versus injustice

We now continue with the distinction between justice and injustice (Colquitt et al., 2015; Hillebrandt & Barclay, 2013). Organizational justice research has focused on the notion of justice, which can be defined as the adherence to traditionally identified justice norms (Colquitt et al., 2015). The most prominent justice theories (e.g., self-interest, group engagement, fairness heuristic, uncertainty management, and deontic models of justice) do not distinguish between justice and injustice (Colquitt et al., 2015). Injustice is considered the opposite of justice on the same continuum (Mayer, 2012). Empirical justice studies have adopted this perspective and mostly measured adherence to justice norms, neglecting the measurement of justice norm violations.

Interestingly, justice scholars have started to deal with the possible distinctiveness between justice and injustice (Cropanzano & Folger, 2011; Gilliland, 2008; Hillebrandt & Barclay, 2013; Mayer, 2012). By applying organizational justice terminology, injustice can be defined as a violation of justice norms. In general, we expect that experiencing justice is a normal and expected state, whereas experiencing injustice is a non-normal and unexpected state that could trigger more intense reactions than the simple absence of justice (Cropanzano & Folger, 2011; Gilliland, 2008; Hillebrandt & Barclay, 2013). This can be explained by negativity bias and evolutionary arguments that suggest that negative stimuli are more salient and trigger stronger reactions than positive stimuli because they threaten our needs and interests (Baumeister et al., 2001; Colquitt et al., 2015). In other words, "bad is stronger than good" (Baumeister et al., 2001: 323). Future research should be more careful when considering injustice and justice as opposites on the same continuum.

To provide insights into the distinctiveness between justice and injustice, Colquitt et al. (2015) conducted two studies. As the main results of the first interview study, the authors reported that reactions toward justice and injustice differ strongly regarding certain outcomes. Injustice evokes more nuanced and differentiated reactions, whereas reactions to justice are vaguer and

expectation based. Specifically, injustice elicits strong reactions regarding the focus of attention, trust, and counterproductive behaviors. However, the interviews also indicated that justice is sometimes more salient than injustice is. For example, justice tends to predict self-esteem-related behaviors, reciprocation, citizenship behaviors, and task performance. Trust is influenced by justice to an extent that is similar to injustice. According to the authors, these results first emphasize the distinctiveness between justice and injustice, and second, they indicate a higher prevalence of injustice compared to justice, as injustice reactions are more precise. In addition, the transcribed interviews included approximately 29,000 words related to injustice, whereas only approximately 21,000 words were related to justice.

To confirm the results of the qualitative study, Colquitt et al. conducted a survey. The results confirmed most of the interview findings regarding the different effects elicited by justice and injustice. Only nuanced reactions were not predicted by injustice or justice. In conclusion, Colquitt et al.'s studies indicate that injustice and justice should not always be considered opposites on the same continuum. It is also noteworthy that the negativity bias and salience of injustice over justice were not confirmed by Colquitt and colleagues, because justice sometimes evokes stronger reactions than injustice. Further empirical research is required to provide a more detailed understanding.

Finally, because of the increased number of studies on injustice, future research is required to provide more information about the construct validity of injustice compared to similar constructs in organizational behavior research, such as incivility, microaggression, bullying, abusive supervision, and counterproductive work behavior. Theoretical and empirical investigations are necessary to provide a more detailed definition of injustice, and how it differs from these constructs.

IMPORTANCE OF ORGANIZATIONAL JUSTICE

Theoretical justice perspectives

Another main topic in organizational justice literature deals with theoretical perspectives to explain why employees are concerned about justice.

The instrumental perspective

The first proposed theoretical perspective to explain why employees are concerned about justice can be termed the instrumental perspective of justice (Adams, 1965; Conlon, 1993; Thibaut & Walker, 1975). This perspective includes theoretical approaches that consider justice as a means of receiving the desired economic and quasi-

economic rewards (Conlon, 1993; Cropanzano, Rupp, et al., 2001). A concrete instrumental model to explain justice effects is, for example, the control model (also called self-interest model) of Thibaut and Walker (1975). According to this model, justice is valued by employees because it increases the likelihood of favorable future outcomes. Thibaut and Walker equated process control with procedural justice and argued that individuals care about procedural justice to influence future outcomes. Procedural justice can, therefore, be described as a direct antecedent of outcome favorability (Blader & Tyler, 2005).

The relational perspective

Past research has found strong effects of justice on employees' attitudes and behaviors, even after controlling for outcome favorability (Cropanzano, Rupp, et al., 2001), indicating that other motives explain why employees care about justice. To address this gap, the relational perspective of justice emerged from the works of Tyler and Lind (1988) and Lind and Tyler (1992). This perspective contrasts with the instrumental perspective by theorizing relational and identity-related motives (Cropanzano, Rupp, et al., 2001). Specifically, the relational perspective of justice is based on two fundamental needs of employees: (a) maintaining a positive identity and (b) belonging (Blader & Tyler, 2005). By experiencing justice in the workplace, employees can satisfy these needs and increase their engagement and motivation. Justice is valued by employees because it provides information about their social identity and the nature of their relationship with the authority figure (Blader & Tyler, 2009). Employees are assumed to have a need to evaluate their relationship with important groups such as their organization or work team, as knowledge about this relationship helps them understand who they are (Lamertz, 2002).

The social exchange perspective

An alternative approach is the exchange perspective of justice, which is based on social exchange theory, a multidisciplinary theory (Blau, 1964; Chernyak-Hai & Rabenu, 2018; Cooper-Thomas & Morrison, 2018; Cropanzano et al., 2017; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005) that is the dominant theory for explaining justice effects (Colquitt et al., 2014, 2013; Rupp et al., 2014). It is theorized that employees reciprocate justice through extra-role behavior and increased commitment (Aşkun, Yeloğlu, & Yıldırım, 2018). This reciprocity develops into a social exchange relationship characterized by felt obligations that are not clearly defined and whose timely fulfillment is open to exchange parties. Despite the wide use of social exchange theory in organizational justice

research, its application is still being refined. For example, social exchange theory can be classified into classic and contemporary theories (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). Classic social exchange theories focus on the goal of maximizing material outcomes based on self-interest, whereas contemporary social exchange theories focus on the relationship quality between exchange parties. Thus, the social exchange perspective can include instrumental and relational motives to explain why people care about justice. Classic social exchange theories (e.g., Blau, 1964, 1968; Homans, 1961, 1974) describe the relationship between two persons based on economic and short-term exchanges. Contemporary social exchange theories (e.g., Colquitt et al., 2011; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005; Cropanzano & Rupp, 2008; Organ, 1988, 1990) include relational and identity-related aspects to describe the importance of justice.

The uncertainty perspective

As the name indicates, the uncertainty perspective of justice deals with the role of uncertainty mechanisms in the workplace and includes fairness heuristic theory (Lind, 2001; Van den Bos, 2001; Van den Bos & Lind, 2001) and uncertainty management theory (Lind & Van den Bos, 2002; Van den Bos, 2009; Van den Bos & Lind, 2002). Both theories try to explain the role of justice in the workplace through its ability to reduce uncertainty. Fairness heuristic theory deals with two fundamental questions: (1) How do we evaluate and react to outcomes? (2) How can we solve the fundamental social dilemma of engaging in cooperation?

Regarding the first question, equity theory has shown that people evaluate the justice of outcomes by comparing their outcomes to those of similar others. However, information on the outcomes of similar others is often unavailable (Van den Bos & Lind, 2001). The fairness heuristic theory proposes that people use procedural justice information as a substitute to evaluate the distributive justice of their outcomes and their supervisor, as procedural justice can be easily interpreted and is often readily available (Van den Bos, 2001).

Regarding the second question, the social dilemma is based on the possibility that the employee will cooperate with the supervisor. On the one hand, such cooperation could create benefits for the employee in terms of information exchange, learning possibilities, and mentoring. However, such cooperation could be related to additional work for the employee, which could even open the door for exploitation. Consequently, employees strive to obtain information to evaluate the trustworthiness of their supervisors. Employees focus on justice perceptions, which function as cues for employees to evaluate the risk of exploitation and rejection in the workplace (Van den Bos & Lind, 2001).

To reduce the uncertainty, employees draw on justice-related information that is first available. This effect is called the primacy effect (Lind, Kray, & Thompson, 2001). Employees use their first available justice information to form a heuristic that guides the formation of their justice perceptions in the future (Van den Bos & Lind, 2001). All new justice information is interpreted in line with the previously formed heuristic. This heuristic is formed quickly and is stable. A change in the heuristic only occurs when strong and contradictory new justice information is available.

While the focus of fairness heuristic theory is on the trustworthiness of an authority figure, uncertainty management theory includes additional sources of workplace-related uncertainty and deals with the relationship between justice and general uncertainty (Lind & Van den Bos, 2002). Uncertain situations in the workplace include entering a new organization, layoffs, organizational change, mergers and acquisitions, technical innovation, and market turmoil (Lind & Van den Bos, 2002). Feelings of uncertainty are uncomfortable and create distress, confusion, and doubt (Van den Bos & Lind, 2002). That is why people try to search justice-related information to cope with the uncertainty (Wolfe et al., 2018).

The deontological moral perspective

Folger (1998, 2001) argued that justice was valued for reasons other than self-interest and introduced moral and ethical reasons as new justice motives. The moral perspective of justice considers justice an end in itself and not a means of achieving a desirable outcome (Cropanzano et al., 2003; Folger & Cropanzano, 2001). The starting point of this perspective is that people have basic respect for human dignity and worth. Adherence to justice norms is a symbol for the respect toward human dignity. Justice norms are considered universal standards and should be upheld in every situation (Beugré, 2010; Folger & Skarlicki, 2008; Montada, 2011). Therefore, behaving in a just way is not only based on economic or relational interests but also the right thing to do. As moral principles and values guide one's feelings, thinking, and actions, people often react strongly and emotionally to those who violate these moral principles (Folger, Cropanzano, & Goldman, 2005). Injustice can trigger strong and negative emotions such as anger, hostility, or resentment. These emotional reactions are called "moral outrage" or "deontic anger" (Folger, Cropanzano, & Goldman, 2005; Folger & Skarlicki, 2008).

The multi-foci perspective of justice

The multi-foci perspective of justice includes the multi-foci model of justice (Cropanzano, Byrne, et al., 2001; Cropanzano, Rupp, et al., 2001; Rupp, Bashshur, &

Liao, 2007; Rupp & Paddock, 2010) and the target-similarity model (Lavelle, Rupp, & Brockner, 2007; Lavelle et al., 2009, 2015), whereby the latter model highlights the role of matching the source of justice with the target of the outcome (Lavelle et al., 2009). Based on the social exchange theory (Blau, 1964), this justice perspective assumes that employees can form multiple relationships with different social exchange partners (e.g., organizations or supervisors) (Rupp et al., 2014). It is assumed that to understand justice effects, it is more important to consider the interaction partner than to classify justice around outcomes, procedures, and interpersonal treatment (Rupp, 2011). The multi-foci perspective argues for a detailed specification and measurement of the source of justice perceptions (e.g., supervisors or organizations).

Although the target-similarity model became a popular framework for investigating justice effects, a recent meta-analysis by Colquitt et al. (2013) challenged the theoretical predictions of the target-similarity model. The results indicated that the matching of source and target had no moderating influence on the strength of the justice effects. However, it should be mentioned that the number of included studies on interpersonal and informational justice is somewhat limited. For example, only three studies were included to evaluate the validity of the target similarity model for the relationship between supervisor-focused informational justice and organizational citizenship behavior (OCB). Similar to informational justice, only four studies evaluated the impact of supervisor-focused interpersonal justice on supervisor-focused OCB. In addition, the considered outcomes were also somewhat limited because important workplace outcomes such as stress, engagement, and satisfaction were not included.

In contrast to the meta-analysis by Colquitt et al. (2013), another recent meta-analysis (Rupp et al., 2014) supported the multi-foci perspective of justice. Their results indicated that the organization of justice around interaction partners leads to stronger effect sizes. Rupp et al. also reported that source-specific social exchange mediated the justice-outcome relationship, providing further support for the multi-foci perspective of justice. The reason for the differences between the two meta-analyses may be that Rupp et al. used source-based justice (and not justice dimensions), a different data analysis technique, a different coding procedure, and a larger number of studies. While Colquitt et al. maintained a four-factor taxonomy of justice for each source (e.g., supervisor-focused interpersonal justice, organization-focused informational justice), Rupp et al. considered overall justice for each source (overall justice from supervisor/organization). Colquitt et al. investigated bivariate meta-analytic correlations, whereas Rupp et al. combined hierarchical multiple regressions with meta-analysis techniques. Concerning coding procedures, it is noteworthy that Colquitt et al. were more liberal in their coding of justice sources. According to their results, they identified the referent

(source) of justice measures in 90% of the studies, whereas Rupp et al. could only identify the referent in 60% of the studies. Different coding procedures may have been applied. The definition of counterproductive work behavior (CWB) also differed in both the meta-analyses. Rupp et al. only included active behaviors (e.g., aggression and retaliation), whereas Colquitt et al. also included passive behavior (e.g., absenteeism and tardiness). Rupp et al. included 647 studies in their meta-analysis, whereas Colquitt et al. included “only” 493 studies. In addition, 213 studies were included in both studies.

The most dominant justice theory

As reviewed above, employees care about justice for different reasons, such as outcome favorability, belonging, status, maintaining a positive identity, trustworthiness, feelings of uncertainty, morality, interpersonal relationships, and obligations. Different theoretical approaches provide a variety of motives for why people care about justice. The question that arises now is which motive is the most powerful? This question is difficult to answer, because it is likely that several justice motives are activated. This means that the proposed motives can complement each other instead of competing with each other (Blader & Tyler, 2005; Colquitt, Greenberg, & Scott, 2005). Furthermore, the salience of the respective justice motive depends on context and individual differences (Blader & Tyler, 2005; Colquitt et al., 2006). No universal theory accounts for all justice effects. Therefore, future research is needed to integrate and compare different theoretical justice approaches (Blader & Tyler, 2005; Colquitt, Greenberg, & Scott, 2005; Colquitt, Greenberg, & Zapata-Phelan, 2005; Van Prooijen et al., 2004). A possible approach to integrate theoretical approaches is the multiple needs model of Cropanzano, Byrne, et al. (2001). This model assumes four human needs: control, belonging, self-esteem, and meaningful existence. Need control is represented through the instrumental perspective and classic social exchange theories. Needs belonging and self-esteem are captured by the relational perspective and contemporary social exchange theories, and the need for a meaningful existence is included in the moral perspective of justice. The multiple needs model can be further extended to include concerns of uncertainty so that all proposed motives to explain the value of justice in the workplace are integrated into one theoretical model.

Justice effects on employee outcomes

Overview of main outcomes in organizational justice research

Prior research has demonstrated that organizational justice predicts affective, attitudinal, and behavioral

outcomes in the workplace (Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001; Colquitt et al., 2001; Colquitt et al., 2013). Examples include positive affect, job satisfaction, organizational commitment, OCB, and task performance (Colquitt et al., 2013; Fassina, Jones, & Uggerslev, 2008; Rupp et al., 2014). Justice is also a precondition for the establishment of a high-quality relationship between employees and their supervisors (Cropanzano & Rupp, 2008). Dysfunctional outcomes that are reduced by justice include negative affect, counterproductive work behavior, turnover intentions, revenge, and retaliation (Colquitt et al., 2013; Khattak et al., 2020; Rupp, 2011). This arguably indicates that justice matters to employees.

The most popular outcomes investigated in organizational justice research are OCB, task performance, trust, organizational identification, and intention to quit. One reason for this popularity of OCB as an outcome is that Organ (1988, 1990) hypothesized in his seminal work on OCB that justice is one of the main pre-conditions for triggering OCB. Therefore, subsequent field studies on OCB included scales to measure the effects of justice on OCB (Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001). OCB has become the referent outcome to show the effects of justice dimensions (Fassina, Jones, & Uggerslev, 2008). Two common explanations have been used to link organizational justice to OCB. The first explanation is the “social exchange explanation,” and the second one is the “social identity-based explanation” (Moorman & Byrne, 2005).

Owing to its high relevance to the achievement of economic goals, task performance has often been analyzed as an outcome of organizational justice (Colquitt et al., 2013). Past studies included different task performance measures, such as self-reports and supervisor evaluations regarding effort, quality, and results in field studies (Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001) or proofreading and brainstorming tasks in laboratory studies (e.g., Kanfer et al., 1987; Weaver & Conlon, 2003). The meta-analytic evidence provided by Colquitt et al. (2013) confirms the importance of justice dimensions in predicting task performance. Although justice dimensions can be assigned to the relational aspect of organizational function (Cropanzano et al., 2007), justice also has instrumental effects (Cropanzano, Byrne, et al., 2001; Cropanzano, Rupp, et al., 2001; Lind & Tyler, 1988; Thibaut & Walker, 1975) that influence instrumental outcomes such as task performance.

Trust in the supervisor is one of the most important preconditions for job performance (Burke et al., 2007). Thus, it is not surprising that organizational justice research has focused on trust in the supervisor as another outcome (e.g., Colquitt & Rodell, 2011; Colquitt et al., 2011; Colquitt & Mueller, 2008; Colquitt et al., 2007; Holtz, 2013; Lewicki et al., 2005). Analyzing the justice–trust relationship in longitudinal field studies, Colquitt et al. showed a strong relationship between the justice dimensions and trust (Colquitt & Rodell, 2011; Colquitt et al., 2011). Meta-analyses of organizational justice and

trust also show high correlations between the justice and trust dimensions (Colquitt et al., 2013; Colquitt et al., 2001; Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001; Dirks & Ferrin, 2002).

Past organizational research has linked justice dimensions to organizational identification in many studies. Strong correlations between justice and identification have been reported, lying in the range between 0.37 and 0.53 (Colquitt et al., 2001; Colquitt et al., 2013; Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001). It is noteworthy that research on organizational justice does not always consider identification as an outcome of justice dimensions. In particular, research conducted by Tyler and Blader (2000, 2003, 2009) assumes a mediating role for identification, also called the social identification mediation hypothesis. According to this hypothesis, procedural and interactional justice increase identification, leading to higher cooperation in terms of extra-role behavior (Blader & Tyler, 2009).

Voluntary turnover is a crucial outcome for organizations for the “simple” reason that a voluntary turnover can cost the organization around 13,000 US-Dollar per employee (Brockner, 2010). Hence, it seems logical that justice researchers include organizational interest in turnover in their studies and investigate the impact of justice on turnover (Conlon, Meyer, & Nowakowski, 2005). However, instead of including real turnover, past research has often included scales to measure turnover intention. Turnover intentions can be considered a direct pre-step of real turnover and are therefore an appropriate measure of turnover (Conlon, Meyer, & Nowakowski, 2005). The general wisdom is that perceptions of justice reduce turnover intentions (Conlon, Meyer, & Nowakowski, 2005). This assumption has also been widely confirmed by quantitative summaries (Colquitt et al., 2001, 2013).

Justice effects in different organizational settings

Prior research has further demonstrated the importance of justice for employees and organizations in a variety of organizational settings such as recruitment, selection, performance evaluations, and layoffs (Cropanzano & Ambrose, 2015; Moliner, Cropanzano, & Martínez-Tur, 2017; Moliner, Martínez-Tur, & Cropanzano, 2017). This has led to improvements in management practices and human resource management systems (Rupp, 2011; Rupp & Aquino, 2009). Organizations can benefit from numerous advantages by considering organizational life through the lens of justice. For example, the acceptance of the application of 360-degree feedback (Karkoulou, Assaker, & Hallak, 2016), the legitimacy of authority decisions (Conlon, Meyer, & Nowakowski, 2005), a reduction in cyberloafing (Kim et al., 2015; Zoghbi-Manrique-de-Lara, 2009), and the implementation of

organizational change measures (Kirkman, Jones, & Shapiro, 2000) can be facilitated if employees are treated with justice. Similarly, Greenberg (1994) investigated justice perceptions in connection with the implementation of a smoking ban in an organization. Smokers who were treated with justice (i.e., respectful treatment and adequate explanations) had more positive attitudes toward the ban (see also Rodell & Colquitt, 2009). Treating employees with justice will make managers appear to be better people and leaders (Byrne et al., 2012). In contrast, neglecting employees' perceptions of justice can have devastating consequences for managers and organizations in terms of reputation, recruitment, sales, fines, strikes, and loss of working morale (Chih et al., 2017; Rupp, 2011).

The benefits of the work environment can also be illustrated in terms of concrete financial figures. Brockner (2006, 2010) argued that laid-off employees are less likely to fulfill lawsuits against their organization when they believe their organization has treated them with justice, such as providing advance warnings and honest explanations about the layoff. One termination lawsuit could cost an organization in the USA around 80,000 US dollars (Brockner, 2010; Lind et al., 2000). Similarly, Lind et al. (2000) reported that approximately 20% of employees who were treated very unjustly (e.g., no respect and no explanations) during layoffs fulfilled a termination lawsuit against their organization. In contrast, only 1% of justly treated employees (e.g., dignified treatment and advance warnings) fulfilled such a lawsuit after having been laid-off. Lawsuits in connection with layoffs can be reduced through justice and lawsuits in connection with workplace discrimination (Goldman, 2003). Focusing on justice could therefore be not only the right thing to do and improve employee well-being (Campbell et al., 2013) but also a profitable business affair (Edwards & Kudret, 2017).

ORGANIZATIONAL JUSTICE IN THE CONTEXT OF TEAMS

Justice climate research

Justice climate is defined as "a distinct unit-level cognition regarding shared justice perceptions of treatment by organizational authorities" (Whitman et al., 2012: 777). With the advent of teams, organizational justice has expanded to the team context (Mossholder, Bennett, & Martin, 1998). The traditional focus of organizational justice research has been on the relationship between individual employees and authority figure. Although research about this relationship yielded valuable results, one limitation started to become "obvious": the neglect of the team context. It took until 1998 when Mossholder et al. conducted the first organizational justice study that included the team context. They investigated the impact

of collective procedural justice on job satisfaction and found that it explains additional variance in job satisfaction beyond individual procedural justice.

The justice climate level measures the average perception of justice with which team members think they are treated by an authority figure. Teams with a high justice climate level perceive that the team is treated with justice by the authority figure, whereas those with a low justice climate level perceive that their team is treated with injustice by the authority figure. Justice climate research examines employees' collective justice perceptions, whereas traditional organizational justice research deals with individual justice perceptions (Colquitt, Greenberg, & Scott, 2005). The referent therefore changed from the individual employee, "How just am I treated by an authority figure?", to the whole team, "How just is my team treated by an authority figure?"

Many empirical studies have confirmed the importance of a justice climate (Li & Cropanzano, 2009; Whitman et al., 2012). Past research has reported that collective justice perceptions predict additional variance beyond individual justice perceptions in key outcomes, such as extra-role behavior, task performance, and organizational commitment (Whitman et al., 2012). Colquitt, Greenberg, and Scott (2005:53) also concluded that "team contexts can magnify the importance of justice in organizations." Similar to individual justice perceptions, justice climates are organized around outcomes, procedures, interactions, and social accounts (e.g., Spell & Arnold, 2007). Significant results were found for all four justice dimensions (e.g., Spell & Arnold, 2007).

Both the justice climate level and justice climate strength should be considered (Colquitt, Zapata-Phelan, & Roberson, 2005). Justice climate strength describes the degree of agreement among team members regarding the extent to which a team is treated (Colquitt et al., 2002). Therefore, it measures within-team variance in justice perceptions (Chan, 1998; Li & Cropanzano, 2009). Justice research has found that high justice climate strength tends to amplify the effects of justice climate level on employee outcomes (Li, Cropanzano, & Molina, 2015; Moliner et al., 2005; Whitman et al., 2012).

Peer justice

Many organizations have shifted from hierarchical to team-based structures, with the continued increasing use of self-managed teams (Chiaburu & Harrison, 2008; Tjosvold, 2008). Prior research has neglected the role of coworkers as sources of justice perception (Cropanzano, Li, & Benson, 2011; Li, Cropanzano, & Bagger, 2013; Molina et al. 2017; Rupp & Paddock, 2010). Without these sources of justice perceptions, an incomplete view

of employees' justice experiences emerges (Ambrose, Rice, & Meyer, 2019; Li et al., 2009; Li, Cropanzano, & Bagger, 2013; Molina et al. 2017; Nasr, El-Akreimi, & Coyle-Shapiro, 2019).

Teams are prone to experiencing problems and difficulties that can be classified as justice-related problems (Li & Cropanzano, 2009). Examples of these justice-related problems are social loafing, missing accountability, individual- versus team-based pay, and individual- versus team-based performance evaluations (Kirkman, Jones, & Shapiro, 2000). Other justice-related problems among team members include free-rider problem, truancy, wasting time, not performing according to the team strategy, and teammates who do not complete projects on time (Behfar et al., 2011). Therefore, it seems likely that teams benefit from an analysis of their teamwork and interpersonal interactions through the organizational justice lens (Molina et al. 2017).

Furthermore, classical management activities, such as task assignments, distribution of workload and responsibilities, and scheduling, are conducted collectively by self-managed team members (Cropanzano, Li, & Benson, 2011; Kirkman, Jones, & Shapiro, 2000; Li, Cropanzano, & Bagger, 2013; Roberson & Williamson, 2012), indicating the importance of distributive justice. Self-managed team members also have the decision-making power to decide on the distribution of tasks, workload, praise, rewards, responsibilities, and assignments (Lavelle, Rupp, & Brockner, 2007; Neville & Brodt, 2010; Roberson & Williamson, 2012). As these members are also responsible for the design of team processes, procedural justice among members should also illustrate a meaningful construct for the daily work experience of team members (Cropanzano, Li, & Benson, 2011; Lavelle et al., 2009; Roberson & Williamson, 2012). Currently, organizations expect members to manage their interpersonal relationships with their teammates, such as discussions, disagreements, and conflict (Roberson & Williamson, 2012), indicating the value of considering interpersonal and informational justice in teams (see also Li, Cropanzano, & Bagger, 2013; Li & Cropanzano, 2009).

A RESEARCH AGENDA FOR ORGANIZATIONAL JUSTICE RESEARCH

Several research gaps were identified as a result of the literature review. These gaps are presented in the following section.

The cultural sensitivity of justice perceptions

The topic of cultural sensitivity and justice is important because of the global orientation of organizations, high

number of migrant workers, and increasing number of global virtual work arrangements. More cross-cultural justice research is needed to generalize previous justice findings from the US context (Shao et al., 2016; Silva & Caetano, 2016). One reason is that most studies apply a US-based definition of justice in terms of the four justice dimensions usually measured using Colquitt (2001). Justice is considered a universal need (Beugré, 2007; Leung & Tong, 2004; Patel, Salih, & Hamlin, 2019), but its definition, interpretation, and implementation can differ across countries (Beugré, 2007; Leung, 2005; Leung & Tong, 2004). Employees with different cultural values could have different expectations about justice (Adamovic, 2023; Beugré, 2007; Steiner, 2001; Taras & Rowney, 2008), so their justice evaluations of events and entities would depend on their cultural and national background. To expand cross-cultural justice research, future research could investigate whether employees from different countries use different justice norms to evaluate justice in the workplace (Adamovic, 2023; Olsen, 2015). This could lead to a more fine-grained understanding of organizational justice in different countries, increasing our understanding of why employees from different countries react differently to justice.

Most cross-cultural research on justice has examined the main effects of cultural values, reporting inconsistent results or weak effect sizes (Taras, Kirkman, & Steel, 2010). A more appropriate approach could be to investigate the moderating role of cultural values on justice effects (Shao et al., 2016). Such a moderating approach of culture can capture the possibility that justice effects are stronger for employees with a specific cultural value orientation or a specific set of cultural values.

Justice in a diverse work environment

The increasing diversity of the workforce (regarding gender, nationality, age, sexual orientation, etc.) has emerged as another trend in many organizations in the Western world (Cachat-Rosset, Carillo, & Klarsfeld, 2019; Kelan & Wrutil, 2018). However, research on diverse teams has yielded inconsistent findings (Shore et al., 2011). Despite the possible salience of justice in diverse teams, only a few attempts have been made to analyze organizational justice in diverse teams (Adamovic, 2020b). To clarify the inconsistent findings of previous diversity research, organizational justice is a promising framework, as dissimilar members often suffer from justice-related problems such as prejudices, stereotypes, categorization, or even discrimination (Stone et al., 2020; Stone-Romero & Stone, 2005). Therefore, the establishment of a just work environment could be a key mechanism or condition for exploiting the potential associated with diversity and dissimilarity (Cachat-Rosset, Carillo, & Klarsfeld, 2019; Le

et al., 2018). Implementing such a work environment may help dissimilar employees feel part of the team and feel less disadvantaged because of their different backgrounds (Dietz et al., 2015).

Furthermore, diverse teams are often characterized by high uncertainty because of the different backgrounds and communication styles of team members (Earley & Gibson, 2002; Presbitero, 2020). This uncertainty is reflected in the interactions among team members, because members are uncertain about how they should behave correctly and treat each other (Behfar, Kern, & Brett, 2006). As theorized by uncertainty management theory, this uncertainty could be reduced by establishing a just work environment in the team and may lead to more self-disclosure of members, improving teamwork and cooperation.

The integration of justice and diversity seems to be promising, as diversity research has tried to answer the question of how diverse individuals can be successfully included in a team or organization (Kaplan, Wiley, & Maertz, 2011). Such inclusion is theorized to be based on decision-making participation, access to information and resources, good connections to supervisors and peers, and a just supervisor (Mor Barak, 2000; Shore et al., 2011). This hypothesized process of inclusion indicates a possible relationship with important justice norms. Justice can contribute to the successful integration of diverse employees (Adamovic et al., 2020), allowing diverse teams to efficiently use their potential (Shore et al., 2011). Recommendations for successful diversity management can also be drawn from the combination of diversity and organizational justice (Colquitt & Jackson, 2006; Cropanzano, Slaughter, & Bachiochi, 2005; Rubino et al., 2018). Many diverse programs have attempted to create equal opportunities (Roberge et al., 2011). In general, a climate of equal opportunity is provided if justice is guaranteed (Cropanzano, Slaughter, & Bachiochi, 2005; Shore et al., 2011). Certain justice rules, such as consistency and the bias suppression rule, can be used to successfully implement a diversity initiative (Colquitt & Jackson, 2006). The application of consistency implies equality of opportunities among employees. The bias suppression rule is important to such a degree that it guarantees the equal treatment of employees during diversity initiatives. Diversity initiatives are not often successful because white male employees (considered the majority) often think they are disadvantaged (Cropanzano, Slaughter, & Bachiochi, 2005).

Taken together, the application of other justice norms can lead to general acceptance and tolerance among diverse employees. This can be the result of a reduction in stereotypical thinking. The understanding and satisfaction of justice needs in diverse teams can help improve diversity initiatives and programs and develop more positive attitudes towards diversity.

Integrating organizational justice and conflict research in the workplace

Justice and conflict are both widely researched concepts in organizational behavior, and intuitive connections exist between them. Nonetheless, the justice–conflict interrelationship is surprisingly under-researched and remains poorly understood (Adamovic, 2020a; Deutsch, 2011; Kerwin, Jordan, & Turner, 2015; Sahoo & Sahoo, 2019; Shapiro & Sherf, 2015; Spell et al., 2011). This is surprising, as the justice–conflict interrelationship is omnipresent in our daily social lives (Deutsch, 2011; Kals & Maes, 2011; Montada, 2011; Törnblom & Kazemi, 2011). Montada (2011:9) even claimed that “all social conflicts are basically justice conflicts.” How often do we hear from people in different situations “that’s not fair,” which then leads frequently to heated discussions and disagreements (Deutsch, 2011). It is easy to imagine that the justice–conflict interconnection also plays a decisive role in organizations that are usually characterized by strong hierarchies, political games, and employees’ striving for power, money, and recognition (Ambrose, 2012; Cropanzano et al., 2007; Gelfand et al., 2012). Indeed, injustice and conflict are ubiquitous in every organization and can have a decisive impact on organizational effectiveness (Colquitt, 2012; Gelfand et al., 2012; Montada, 2011). For instance, low pay, biased procedures, or disrespectful treatment are usually perceived as unjust situations that could give rise to conflict.

Why is there a lack of integrative research? One reason could be related to the focal level of the analysis. Studies on organizational justice and conflict types have been conducted at different levels and in different relationships of analysis (Adamovic, 2020a). Although most organizational justice research has focused on vertical relationships between leaders and members, most conflict research has focused on horizontal relationships between team members. However, based on recent developments in both research streams, a combination of these studies seems to be feasible. Justice research has recently begun to examine teammates as sources of justice perception (Ambrose, Rice, & Meyer, 2019; Li, Cropanzano, & Bagger, 2013). Similarly, conflict-type research has widened its scope to include the hierarchical relationships between managers and subordinates.

Useful information and a fine-grained understanding could be provided through the application of Colquitt (2001) and Jehn (1995) taxonomies (Adamovic, 2020a) because justice dimensions and conflict types have different effects on outcomes (Colquitt et al., 2013; De Wit et al., 2012). To understand the effects of conflict type on justice dimensions, it is also necessary to examine the conflict management approach of conflict parties (Adamovic, 2020a). For example, the possible dysfunctional effects of conflict on justice are dampened by cooperative conflict management (Shapiro & Sherf, 2015),

whereas competitive conflict management transforms conflict into a negative process, increasing perceptions of injustice. Future research can advance the integration of organizational justice with both conflict research streams (conflict types and conflict management styles). Conflict management strategies may be key to understanding and effectively managing the interrelationship between injustice and conflict (Shapiro & Sharf, 2015). Interestingly, the choice of conflict management style can be influenced by justice perceptions. Employees with high perceptions of justice may apply cooperative conflict strategies, whereas those who perceive injustice may apply competitive conflict strategies. However, recent conflict management research has demonstrated that many different variables influence the application of conflict management strategies, such as personality, demographic characteristics, values, leadership, organizational structure, reward systems, industry and community context, and national and regional cultures (Gelfand et al., 2008, 2012).

Another avenue for future research is the analysis of prescriptive justice expectations in connection with conflicts. Prescriptive justice expectations refer to employees' expectations of how supervisors, coworkers, and organizations should behave. Resulting from different justice expectations and preferences, conflict about "what is just?" can develop (see also Deutsch, 2011). A useful sample is multinational teams because of the salience of different justice expectations in this context, created by different cultural backgrounds (Beugré, 2007). This allows the integration of conflict research because it often analyzes conflict dynamics in diverse teams (Jehn et al., 2012).

To generalize the injustice–conflict interrelationship, future research should adopt a cross-cultural perspective. For instance, a high-power distance culture may influence leader–member interactions in three ways. First, different rules may apply to leaders in these cultures, causing members to perceive less leader injustice (Lian, Ferris, & Brown, 2012). Second, these cultures discourage disobedient and conflictual behavior toward authorities in the name of preserving social order, leading to fewer injustice-based conflicts (Liu, Yang, & Nauta, 2013). Third, members may fear a powerful leader's negative responses (Liu et al., 2011), leading to the avoidance of intense conflict.

Future research also needs to carefully consider the distinction between injustice and justice (Colquitt et al., 2015) as well as between justice and fairness (Goldman & Cropanzano, 2015). Injustice (i.e., violation of justice norms) may be more strongly related to conflict than justice (acting in line with justice norms) because prior research indicates that people often have a negativity bias (Baumeister et al., 2001) and therefore show stronger reactions to negative events. The moral perspective of justice also argues that the violation of justice may trigger strong reactions in terms of deontic anger (Folger,

Cropanzano, & Goldman, 2005). Further research is needed to investigate whether the distinction between justice and fairness matters for conflict and management.

Changing nature of work and organizational justice

The COVID-19 pandemic has forced employees in many countries to work from home (Chamakiotis, Panteli, & Davison, 2021; Dwivedi et al., 2020). Considering virtual work arrangements through a justice lens may help organizations make decisions about the telework eligibility of their employees in the future. Furthermore, it may help organizations create virtual inclusion and a virtual work environment that allows employees, despite physical distance, to express their concerns and issues (Adamovic et al., 2022). Similarly, female and minority employees may feel socially excluded and have more difficulties to connect to their coworkers and managers when they work from home. Training employees and managers based on an organizational justice framework (Skarlicki & Latham, 2005) may help improve the virtual inclusion of these employees. Future research can investigate and compare employees' justice perceptions for different virtual work arrangements, and whether there are different justice perceptions depending on employees' demographic backgrounds.

Furthermore, research on the situation of workers in a shared economy may benefit from adopting a justice lens. An increasing number of gig workers often have no job security, limited work rights, and no representation. Organizational justice researchers can interview and survey these workers to assess the extent of injustice (e.g., low pay, no job security, no representation, being supervised by an algorithm, and disrespectful customers) that they experience and to provide recommendations for addressing these injustices. This allows organizational justice to make important practical contributions.

Examples of justice initiatives at the corporate level that are helpful to organizations in the shared economy include affirmative action programs, corporate social responsibility, and social entrepreneurship (Edwards & Kudret, 2017; Rupp, 2011). Such measures aim to increase the justice perceptions of different stakeholders such as employees, customers, and NGOs. By focusing on justice, managers and organizations can benefit from competitive and strategic advantages.

To create a just workplace, managers can "flatten" organizational hierarchies, such as introducing a management-by-walking around style and asking leaders to invest some of their time by treating employees in a just way (Brockner, 2010). In addition, organizations can implement consistent and unbiased procedures and policies to increase employees' perceptions of justice. No direct financial costs arise for organizations. Organizational justice can also become a part of the training

programs of new supervisors relating to the topic of impression management (Skarlicki & Latham, 2005).

Another important and current topic that has not been integrated into organizational justice research is the integration of migrants (Le et al., 2018) and refugees in the workforce (Newman et al. 2018; Cooney-O'Donoghue, Adamovic, & Sojo, 2022). These groups of workers often feel socially excluded and suffer from discrimination in the workplace and society (Binggeli, Dietz, & Krings, 2013). The integration of the organizational justice research stream may help create an inclusive climate for organizations characterized by tolerance, respect, and open-mindedness (Le et al., 2018).

CONCLUSION

The amount of organizational justice research is impressive, including a large variety of theoretical and methodological approaches. Considering the large number of studies and future research avenues, one could conclude that organizational justice research is flourishing. Although we agree with many current developments in the organizational justice literature, we emphasize that future research should not forget its main goal: fighting injustices that employees experience and create just places to work. All the reviewed theoretical frameworks and studies should not be the final goal of justice research, but rather an important means to achieve the goal of creating just workplaces (Graso et al., 2020). Otherwise, organizational justice research will have difficulty maintaining its promise in terms of establishing a just work environment. It is crucial that future research collaborates with organizations to conduct intervention studies (Greenberg, 2010) and to consider current challenges and developments in workplaces and society to address social issues at work (Adamovic, 2022; Adamovic & Leibbrandt, 2022; Harley & Fleming, 2021; Rubino et al., 2018). Integrating the context in its empirical investigation will allow organizational justice research to facilitate the provision of practical recommendations and create just workplaces.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The author declares no conflict of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Not applicable.

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How to cite this article: Adamovic, M. (2023) Organizational justice research: A review, synthesis, and research agenda. *European Management Review*, 20(4), 762–782. <https://doi.org/10.1111/emre.12564>